

What To Do After a Wildfire



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A home is the center of your family. When it's damaged by wildfire, it can be overwhelming to consider everything that needs to be repaired and replaced. The following are some best practices to follow in the event of a loss:

Notify Your Insurance Carrier(s) and Register for FEMA Benefits

- ☐ **Contact your insurance company Home and Auto** as soon as possible to let them know about the damage. A trusted insurance broker can help you with this process. Some homeowners' insurance covers wildfires, but it's essential to understand the specifics of your policy. Be prepared to provide details about the fire, including the date, time, location, and description of damages.
- ☐ You should also **notify your mortgage servicer**. Homeowners are still responsible for making mortgage payments even if the home is lost in a fire. Sometimes, mortgage lenders may temporarily suspend mortgage payments while you rebuild or find alternative housing.
- ☐ Register for FEMA Benefits to see if you qualify for relief.

Take advantage of State, Local, and National Resources

- ☐ **Contact your local disaster relief service**, such as the American Red Cross or 211 Resources (Link Below). They can assist you with immediate needs, such as finding food, clothing, medicine, and a place to stay.

Document the Damage

- ☐ Check with the fire department to learn when to return home. It can take days, possibly a week or more, before an area can be made safe to return to but your documentation can start now.
- ☐ If you were able to video assets in the home before you left that is great. You can also search for pictures and Videos of items in the home to start your documentation and inventory the insurance company may need.
- ☐ Once you return home, but before extensive clean-up begins, you should document the damage with photos and video. It's important to get good pictures of all damaged structures and contents to help your insurance company.

Keep and Replace Records

- ☐ **Begin saving receipts for any money you spend on the fire loss.** The receipts may be needed later by the insurance company and to prove any losses claimed on your income tax. Track all expenses due to restoration or relocation.
- ☐ **Begin to replace any valuable documents lost in the fire.** Those include driver's licenses, auto registration, titles, and deeds, passports, Social Security or Medicare cards, insurance policies, and more.
- ☐ Later in the process make sure to check with an accountant or the IRS about special benefits for people recovering from fire loss.

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Prevent Further Damage

- ☐ Once damage is documented, take measures to protect any insured property from further damage. When safe, make immediate temporary repairs to prevent any more damage. Be prepared to explain your rationale to the adjuster.
- ☐ Once you are ready for permanent repairs, connect with your insurance company and determine the extent of repairs covered. Obtain itemized invoices for all repairs related to the damage.

Additional Coverages

Ask your insurance company about all possible coverages such as:

- ☐ Direct physical loss or damage to your personal property – Clothes, Furniture, Toys, Etc.
- ☐ Ingress/Egress: Coverage for losses when access to property is limited. i.e. Hoteling, Driving to Safety Locations and any extra expenses such as relocation or additional living expenses.
- ☐ Utility Service Interruption Coverage: This can cover losses procured by an interruption of utility services due to property damage of service provider.
- ☐ Auto Coverage should be evaluated for Car Rental coverage after loss. They will likely extend coverage until you receive your check for a total loss or car has been repaired.

Additional Resources

- [American Red Cross](#): Emergency response resource for disaster relief and recovery support services available 24/7 to help those affected by natural disasters across the country. 800-733-2767
- [211 Community Resources](#): Comprehensive source of information about local community resources and support services with thousands of local experts available to help 24/7. Calls are confidential and can be anonymous. Dial 211
- [InciWeb](#): Interagency all-risk incident information management system developed to provide the public with a single source for wildfire.
- [National Interagency Fire Center](#): Organization provides cooperation and collaboration among national and state wildland fire entities.
- [CalFire](#): Provides list of active wildfire, historical data, and statistics.
- [FIRMS](#): Provides satellite imagery, active fire/hotspots, and related products to identify the location, extent, and intensity of wildfire. Global data is available within 3 hours of satellite observation; US and Canada active fire detections are available in real-time.
- [FEMA](#): Register here to start the process with FEMA support. Link: [Home | disasterassistance.gov](https://www.fema.gov/disasterassistance)